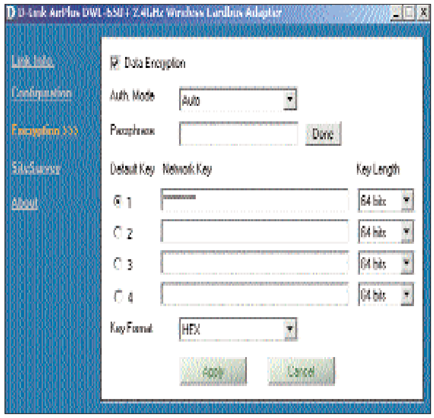
Wi-Fi hacker alert

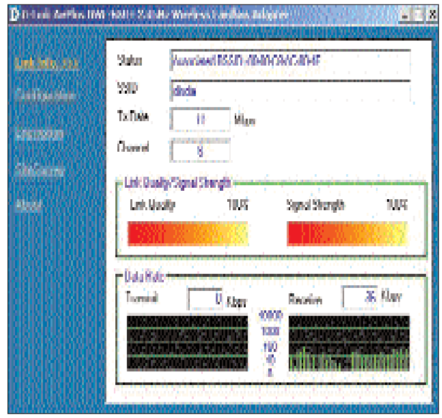
Security is a critical issue with wireless transmission. As the signal in a WLAN is freely transmitted in space, anybody in the vicinity has access to it. This can include a hacker sitting in a car parked just outside your home or office. SSID are used to identify the wireless adapters installed in a wireless environment, by access points. The SSID is broadcasted freely many times by an access point. A hacker with reasonable experience and the help of an 802.11 analysis tool, can sniff the network to get the SSID, and hence, free access to the home or office network. Wireless networks can enable WEP (Wired Equivalent Privacy), a form of encryption, available in 64, 128 and 256-bit that will keep amateur hackers away. However, an experienced hacker can gain access by monitoring the data transmission and decoding the WEP-encrypted information. WPA (Wireless Protected Access) a more secure encryption standard, is in under development and will be available soon.

Now, all you have to do is configure the clients.

STEP 1 Install the adapter drivers and then shut down the PC and plug the adapter card into the PCI/PCMCIA slot and restart the system. Wait for the driver to initialise the adapter.



Set the encryption level as per your network



Fine tune the quality of your LAN connection using the Configuration utility

STEP 2 Once the hardware is initialised, double-click on the adapter card configuration icon in the system tray. This will launch the configuration utility. Here the user doesn't have to do anything, as most of the settings, including SSID and encryption key, are automatically picked up by the adapter card from the Access Point.

STEP 3 Check the signal strength available at the place the wireless desktop or laptop is placed double clicking utility resting in the taskbar.

While setting up a wireless network, it is important to remember to place the access point carefully, as metal tables, cupboards, and cabinets filled with clothes can cause a drop in throughput. Though a wireless connection is the best choice for a multi-storeyed house, there will be many obstacles, such as walls, flooring, metal tables and even microwave ovens, which might lower the data throughput. To avoid this, move the access point around to find the best place where the clients get the maximum signal strength. The same process will have to be repeated for the client placement. Once you find the best place for them, you're all set to do as you please in your networked haven.

ALIASGAR PARDAWALA
(aliasgar_pardawala@thinkdigit.com)